FALL 2026 · A FIELD GUIDE

The State of the *American Apple*

A smaller crop. A Honeycrisp glut. A new crisp kid in town.
And what to buy this week.

Sources: USApple/USDA, Produce Business, Serious Eats, UMN, AppleRankings. Full list on the last slide.

Video & photos: MikeyMoose, Dietmar Rabich / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA)

THE 30-SECOND VERSION

Four apples to know this fall

HEALTHIEST

Dark red, peel on

Red Delicious types top several antioxidant studies. Granny Smith has the least sugar.

BEST TASTING

SweeTango

Tops expert rankings at 97/100. Only in stores now, Sept to Oct.

MOST POPULAR

Honeycrisp

#1 in dollars. Also in a glut, and often mediocre.

RISING

Cosmic Crisp

Sales up ~37% in a year. Stays crisp for months.

Sources: AppleRankings (Brian Frange), Produce Business (52 wks to June 2026), Drogoudi et al. 2008, Chile study (doi 10.4067/S0718-58392010000400001).

Photo: Dietmar Rabich / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0)

STATE OF THE CROP, 2026/27

263M

bushels of US apples

−7% vs. last year **−3%** vs. 5-year average

~45M bu
exported (+2%)

~60%
of grower costs are labor

At or below cost
farm prices for several varieties

USApple/USDA estimate, Aug 21, 2026. USApple did not publish a final adjusted national number this year.

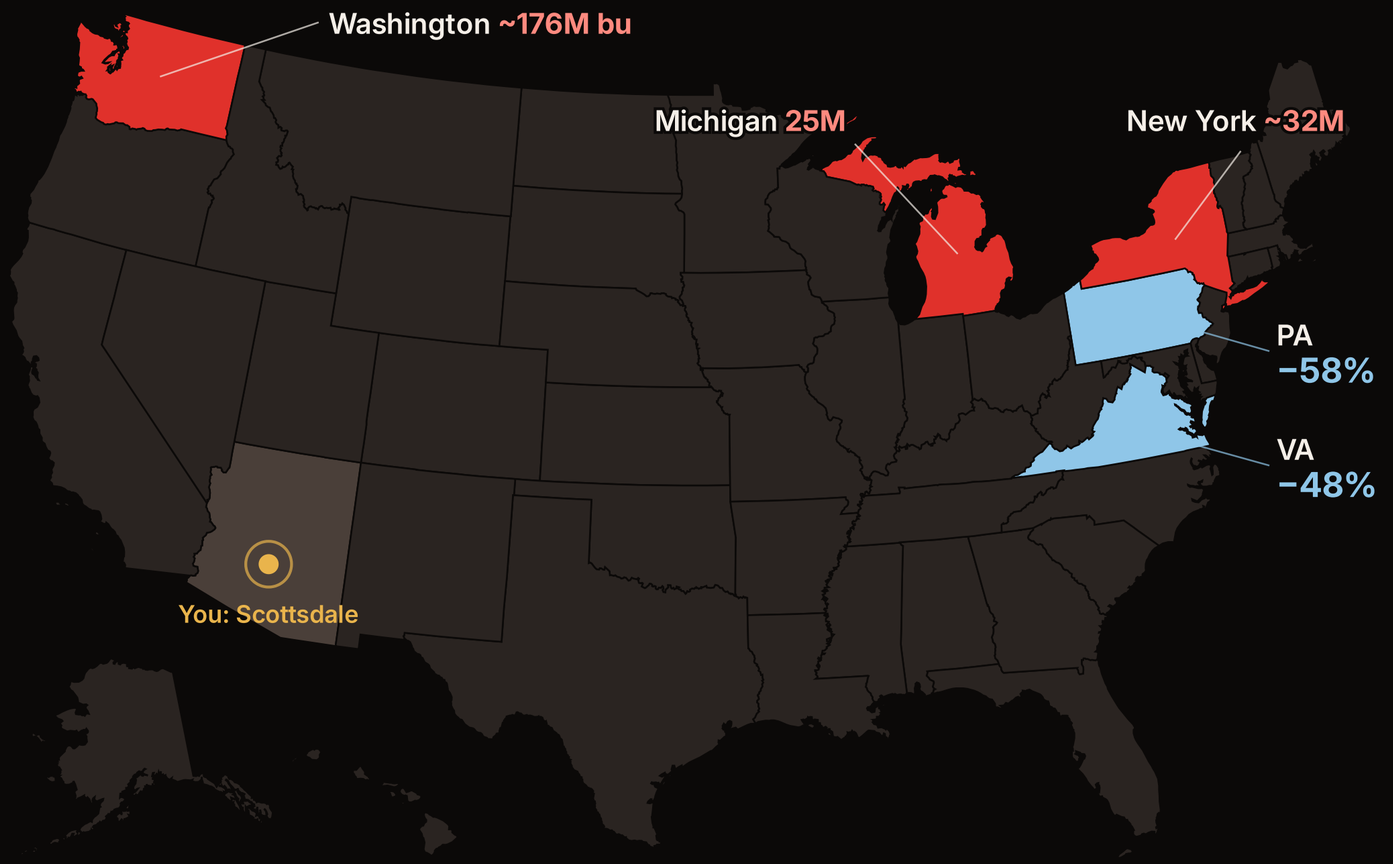
Sources: USApple 2026 Industry Outlook; Commodity Marketing Board (CMB).



Photo: Dietmar Rabich / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0)

WHERE APPLES COME FROM

Three states grow most of it. A spring freeze hit two others.



Big three growers

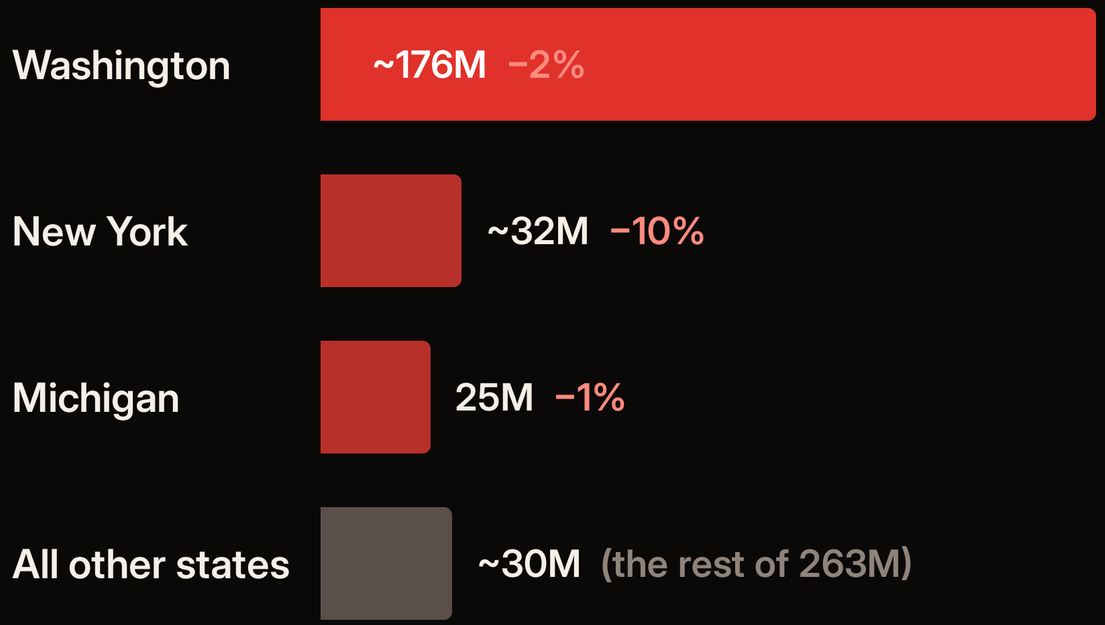
Hit by April freeze

Washington alone grew about **2 of every 3** US apples this year (176M of 263M bushels).

Source: USApple/USDA 2026 Outlook (Aug 21, 2026). Map: US Census boundaries via us-atlas.

CROP BY STATE, 2026

Washington is the whole ballgame



Million bushels, change vs. last year. "All other states" is 263M minus the three named states.

Source: USApple/USDA 2026 Outlook; FreshPlaza.

THE APRIL FREEZE

−58% Pennsylvania

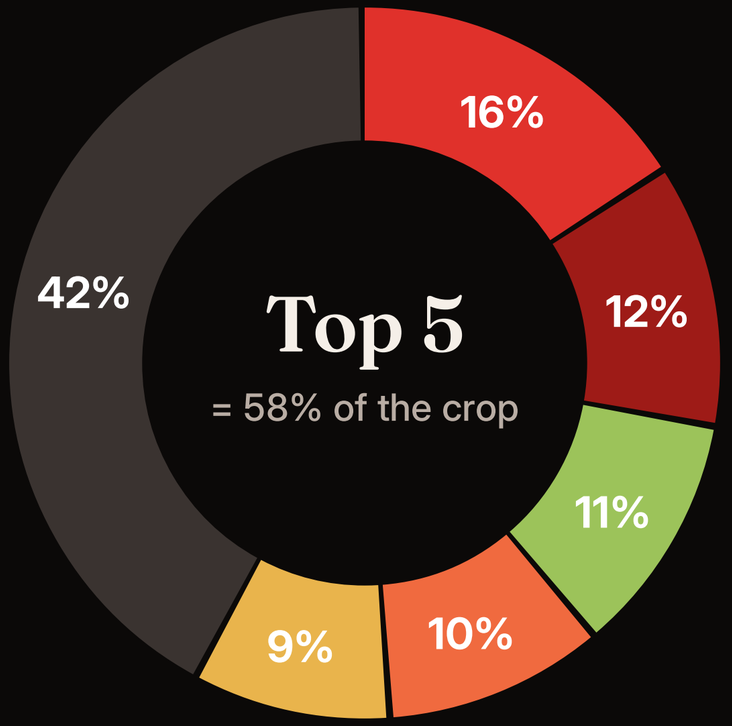
−48% Virginia

A hard April freeze hit at bloom time and cut both crops roughly in half.

Photo: Haneburger / Wikimedia Commons (Public domain) (illustrative)

WHAT AMERICA GROWS (BY VOLUME)

The old guard still leads. It's also shrinking.



Gala	16%
Red Delicious	12%
Granny Smith	11%
Honeycrisp	10%
Fuji	9%
Everything else	42%

↑ GROWING (5 YRS)

Granny Smith · Honeycrisp · Cosmic Crisp · Pink Lady

↓ SHRINKING (5 YRS)

Gala · Red Delicious · Fuji

Source: USApple 2026 Industry Outlook. Share of 2026 crop volume.

WHERE THE MONEY GOES

Honeycrisp wins the till. Cosmic Crisp is coming fast.

1	Honeycrisp	2	Gala
3	Granny Smith	4	Cosmic Crisp ~10% of sales

SALES GROWTH, 52 WEEKS TO JUNE 2026



7M+ bu
Cosmic Crisp is now the largest stored variety

2032
stays Washington-only until then

Sources: Produce Business, "Washington Apples Regain Momentum"; USApple 2026 Outlook.



Photo: Bri / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0)

HONEYCRISP: THE RISE AND THE HANGOVER

From reject to superstar to surplus

1960
The cross

Made at the University of Minnesota.

1977
Discarded

Tagged as a reject.

1982
Rescued

Pulled back and re-tested.

1988
Named

It gets the name Honeycrisp.

1991
Released

Out to growers and shoppers.

2008
Patent ends

Anyone can grow it.

Now
Glut

Surplus 71% above the 5-yr average.

RISE

FALL

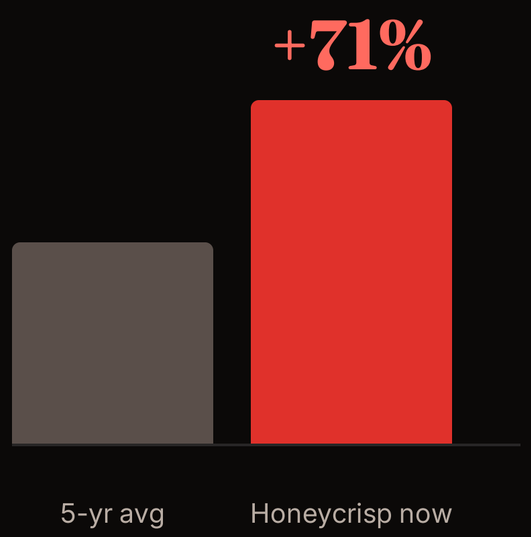
Sources: University of Minnesota (mnhardy.umn.edu/honeycrisp); Serious Eats, "How Honeycrisp Apples Went From Marvel to Mediocre".

Photo: MikeyMoose / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0)

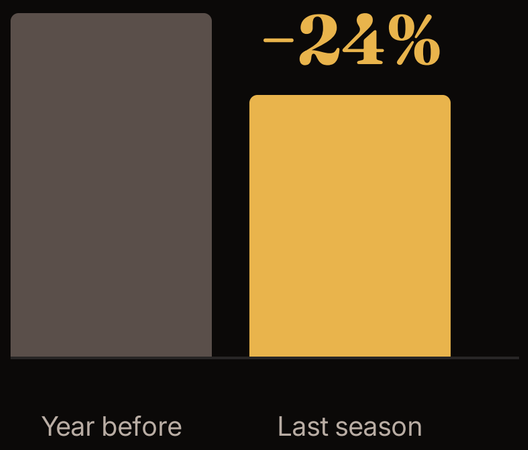
THE HONEYCRISP HANGOVER

Too many apples, too little money

Supply vs. 5-year average



Grower prices, last season



> Shelf price around **$1.70/lb**, per Serious Eats. Good for shoppers. Rough for growers.

Sources: Serious Eats (surplus, ~$1.70/lb); Commodity Marketing Board (grower prices ~24% below prior year).



Photo: Quintin Soloviev / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY 4.0)

DIAGRAM

Why your Honeycrisp tastes so-so

1

Big, juicy cells

The famous snap. Cells burst with juice. Bred in Minnesota.

→

2

Grown warm

Planted big in Washington. Warm or overcropped fruit tastes "mild."

→

3

Stress shows

Bitter pit (brown spots), sunburn and bruising.

→

4

Long storage

Months in storage dull the flavor.

→

5

Mediocre + glut

A so-so apple, and far too many of them.

The fix: buy fall-harvested Honeycrisp now. Firm, no brown spots.

Sources: Serious Eats; University of Minnesota (UMN); Tong et al. 1999.

Photo: MikeyMoose / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0)

THE FAMILY TREE

Honeycrisp's kids got its crunch



Honeycrisp

Huge juicy cells, high snap



HONEYCRISP × ZESTAR!

SweeTango

Same snap, more tang. Short season: Sept to Oct.



HONEYCRISP × ENTERPRISE

Cosmic Crisp

Stays crisp for months. Washington-only until 2032.

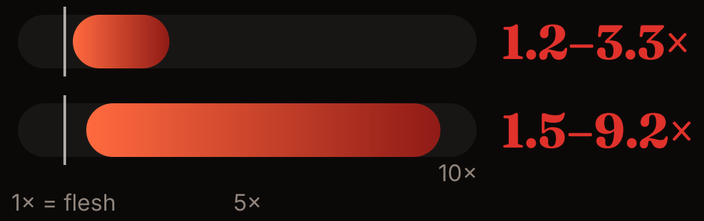
Club apples: licensed and grown under quality rules. SweeTango · Envy · Pink Lady · Cosmic Crisp · Kanzi · Opal

Sources: University of Minnesota; Tong et al. 1999; USApple 2026 Outlook.

HEALTH

The good stuff is in the peel

HOW MUCH MORE THE PEEL HAS THAN THE FLESH



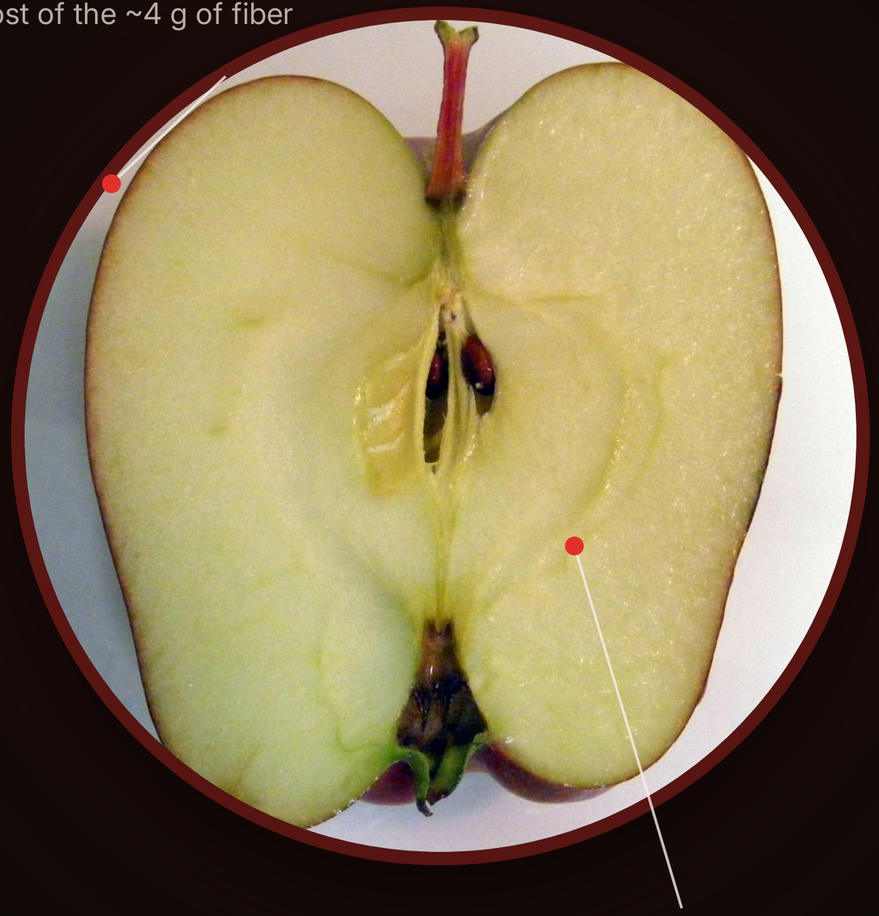
2–5×
more phenolics in peel (2016 study)

~4 g
fiber per apple, mostly in the skin

~19 g
sugar, about the same in every variety

> Peeling costs you more than picking the "wrong" apple. Darker, redder skin roughly means more antioxidants.

Peel
thin red skin: most of the phenolics, and most of the ~4 g of fiber



Flesh
the baseline (1×)

Sources: Drogoudi et al. 2008 (Scientia Horticulturae); 2016 peel/flesh study (Intl. J. of Fruit Science).

Photo: J.smith / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0)

TOP 5 HEALTHIEST

Eat dark, eat the skin

1. **Red Delicious**
   Highest peel and flesh polyphenols in several studies.

2. **Granny Smith**
   Least sugar, lots of acid. Antioxidant rank varies by study.

3. **Pink Lady**
   Red-blush peel, solid phenolics. Tart, moderate sugar.

4. **Fuji**
   Middle of the pack on phenolics. Most sugar on this list.

5. **Any red apple, peel on**
   The one you'll actually eat. Peel beats variety.



Sources: Chile study (doi 10.4067/S0718-58392010000400001); Greek study (Drogoudi 2008); 2016 flesh study; Turkish CUPRAC study (J Sci Food Agric).

Photo: Sonita Lewis / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 2.0)

TOP 5 BEST TASTING

Sweet-tart beats plain sweet



AppleRankings scores (out of 100), plus reader votes. Bars start at 70 to show the gaps.

Sources: AppleRankings (Brian Frange) via Food & Wine and WBUR Here & Now (Oct 6, 2026); The Globe and Mail reader vote.

Photo: MikeyMoose / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0)

BUY THIS WEEK IN SCOTTSDALE

Your October shopping list

1

SweeTango

Grab it now at Sprouts, Whole Foods, Fry's or AJ's. Gone by about November.

2

Fresh Honeycrisp

The fall 2026 crop is just picked. Best time of year to buy. Firm, no brown spots.

3

Cosmic Crisp

The safe pick if SweeTango is sold out.

!

Fridge, not counter

Arizona heat softens apples fast on the counter.

> Rule of thumb: firm fruit, no brown spots, peel on, kept cold.

Sources: research brief, Oct 13, 2026; University of Minnesota; Serious Eats.

Photo: Dietmar Rabich / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0)

SOURCES

Where the numbers came from

USApple, 2026 Industry Outlook Report (Aug 21, 2026): usapple.org/news-resources/usapple-releases-2026-industry-outlook-report

Serious Eats, "How Honeycrisp Apples Went From Marvel to Mediocre": seriouseats.com/how-honeycrisp-apples-went-from-marvel-to-mediocre-8753117

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Commodity Marketing Board: commodity-board.com/u-s-apple-market-steadies-as-production-dips-and-exports-rebound

FreshPlaza: freshplaza.com/north-america/article/9847583/washington-apple-crop-may-be-10-smaller-in-2026/

Food & Wine, apple varieties ranked: foodandwine.com/best-apple-varieties-ranked-11822723

WBUR Here & Now (Oct 6, 2026): wbur.org/hereandnow/2026/10/06/apples-ranking

The Globe and Mail reader vote: theglobeandmail.com/life/style/food-and-drink/article-best-apple-varieties-vote/

University of Minnesota: mnhardy.umn.edu/honeycrisp

Tong et al. 1999, Honeycrisp softening in storage: experts.umn.edu/en/publications/comparison-of-softening-related-changes-during-storage-of-honeycr/

Chile study, Red Delicious peel: doi.org/10.4067/S0718-58392010000400001

Drogoudi et al. 2008: sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0304423807002993

2016 peel/flesh study: tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/15538362.2016.1262304

Turkish CUPRAC study: scijournals.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1002/jsfa.5810

Photos: Wikimedia Commons, by MikeyMoose, Dietmar Rabich, Quintin Soloviev, Haneburger, J.smith, Bri, Sonita Lewis (CC BY / BY-SA / GFDL / public domain). Map: us-atlas (US Census).

Links checked Oct 13, 2026. Publisher links for the three journal studies were found via search, not opened.